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Locality and Social Representation: Space, Discourse and Alternative Definitions of the Rural

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Abstract — There is currently a debate taking place in the 'rural' literature concerning the fundamental issue of the definition of 'the rural'. Two main conventional approaches to this issue are to define the rural in either descriptive or socio–cultural terms. However, both can be criticized from a theoretical standpoint for adopting an inadequate conceptualization of space. As a result, there is an increasing but problematic tendency to try to define the rural in terms of a distinctive type of locality. However, there is yet another means of definition, which has been somewhat neglected in the literature. This alternative can best be approached from an understanding of the theory of social representations and the contrasting discourses of academics and non-academics. A modified version of the theory enables us to define the rural in terms of the disembodied cognitive structures which we use as rules and resources in order to make sense of our everyday world, through both discursive and non-discursive actions. Moreover, in an increasingly post-modern era it can be argued that such an 'immaterial' definition may be assuming dominance over its locality-based alternative.

Introduction

In his introductory editorial for this journal in 1985, Cloke spent some time examining the definition of the rural and concluded that further analysis was necessary before such an apparently straightforward issue — one that 'trip[s] very easily off the tongue' (p. 4) — could be satisfactorily resolved. A similar point has been made by Falk and Pinhey (1978) and, much earlier, by Bealer *et al.* (1965). Indeed, Gilbert (1982) observed that the definition of the rural has been in dispute for at least 70 years. This paper is meant as a contribution to this ongoing debate and as a companion piece to Hoggart's (1990) response to Cloke's challenge.

The paper is divided into two principal sections. In the first, I outline three broad approaches to defining the rural and conclude that only the last of these, discussing the problem of the rural as a locality, is adequate. The other two alternatives, namely descriptive definitions and definitions based on socio–cultural characteristics, rest upon a false conceptualization of space. However, there is yet another way of defining the rural, which can be regarded as existing in parallel to the locality-based definition, shifting attention away from a concentration on tangible space in favour of the non-tangible space of 'social representations'. This alternative focus provides the subject matter for the second section of the paper, where I introduce the theory of social representations and its relevance to the rural definition debate. I conclude by suggesting, somewhat provocatively, that the social representation of the rural may be assuming increasing significance *vis-à-vis* the rural as locality as we move into an increasingly post-modern era.

The rural as space: description, spatial determinism and rural localities

Descriptive definitions

Just as there are 'urban areas', 'residential areas', 'suburban areas' and a host of other types of area, so too can we define 'rural areas' according to their socio–spatial characteristics. This way of defining the rural concentrates upon that which is observable and measurable and, hence, leads to descriptive definitions. Such empiricism accepts that the rural exists and concerns itself with the correct selection of parameters with which to define it (Pratt, 1989).

The most widely known example of this type of definition is Paul Cloke's 'index of rurality for England and Wales' (Cloke, 1977, 1978; Cloke and Edwards, 1986). This developed a classification scheme devised by the Department of the Environment (DOE, 1971) and is based upon 16 census variables covering employment, population, migration, housing conditions, land use and remoteness. Degrees of rurality were obtained from the scores calculated using a principal components analysis of the variables. These indices were divided into quartiles in order to simplify analysis.

Table 1 lists a number of other descriptive definitions of the rural, each focusing on a different aspect of the socio–spatial environment which the author felt was the 'essence' of rurality. Typical uses of these definitions included justifying a study as being 'rural' and the production of national maps of rurality. With notable exceptions, the definitions were not utilized within a more theoretical framework for distinguishing the rural from the urban but concentrated upon their own coherence.

In spite of the technical consideration which went into the production of these varied definitions, there are a number of criticisms which can be levelled at them (see also Halfacree, 1992, pp. 66–73; Clark, 1984; Openshaw, 1985; Openshaw *et al.*, 1980).

Table 1. Descriptive definitions of the rural

Statistical	— Cloke, 1977, 1978; Cloke and Edwards, 1986
	— Openshaw, 1985
	— Harper, 1987a; Donnelly and Harper, 1987
Administrative	— Stevens, 1946
	— Lassey, 1977
	— OPCS in Openshaw, 1985
Built-up area	— Cherry, 1976
	— Denham, 1984
	— OPCS, 1986
	— Craig, 1987
Functional regions	— Coombes *et al.*, 1982; CURDS, 1983–1984; Champion and Coombes, 1984; Champion *et al.*, 1984, 1987
Agricultural	— Vince, 1952
	— Robertson, 1961
	— Wibberley, 1972
	— Newby, 1977, 1978, 1979, 1980, 1987; Newby *et al.*, 1978; Newby and Buttel, 1980
	— Friedland, 1982
	— Gilbert, 1982
Population size/density	— Clout, 1972
	— Lewis, 1979
	— Urry, 1984
	— Fothergill *et al.*, 1985

Sources: Halfacree, 1992, pp. 63–66; Cloke, 1985, p. 4.

These include the historical relativism of the classifications; the sensitivity of the classifications to the definitions of the variables, the choice of variables, the data quality and the statistical technique; the question of the scale at which the rural is defined and the importance of context; and the neglect of qualitative data. By way of a summary, it can be argued that each of the definitions given in Table 1 relate to a specialized use and are therefore not a general measure of rurality. Hence, statistical definitions are geared towards socio–economic studies; administrative definitions towards political studies; built-up area definitions towards land-use studies; functional definitions towards economic studies; agricultural definitions towards land-use and social relations studies; and population density definitions towards service provision studies. More generally, the definitions are all geared towards various planning and academic purposes (Craig, 1988; see also Rodwin and Hollister, 1984).

This last observation is not really a criticism of the descriptive definitions themselves but it cautions us against using any one of them as *the* means of defining the rural, even if the 'technical problems' could be overcome satisfactorily. The 'definitions' are better seen as research tools for the articulation of specific aspects of the rural than as ways of defining the rural. Their methods involve trying to fit a definition to *what we already intuitively consider to be rural*, in the absence of any other justification as to why they should be regarded as representing the rural. In other words, they are trying to put the cart before the horse, the rural having been already 'defined' by those doing the classifying. As Shields expresses it, in the context of discussing similar attempts to 'define' the 'Far North' of Canada:

> the appeal to popular perception is indicative of a tautological circle in all of these studies: starting out from commonsensical intuition, statistics are gathered and then interpreted in the light of commonsense. Thus ennobled by the clothes of empiricism, commonsense is represented as scientific conclusions (1991, p. 168).

Descriptive methods only describe the rural, they do not define it themselves. Attention must thus be given to *what* it is that they are trying to articulate, a point to which we shall return after considering the socio–cultural way of defining the rural.

Socio–cultural definitions

A second approach to defining the rural concentrates on highlighting the extent to which people's socio–cultural characteristics vary with the type of environment in which they live. In short, socio–

cultural definitions of the rural assume that population density affects behaviour and attitudes (Hoggart and Buller, 1987). This assumed correlation between social and spatial attributes has been a strong force in the organization and development of rural studies but has changed in character and sophistication over the years.

In 1938, Louis Wirth set forth his proposal that 'urbanism' represented a distinct 'way of life'. 'Urbanism' was characterized as being dynamic, unstable, mobile in stratification and impersonal, with contacts being determined by one's precise situation at the time (work, home, leisure). Counterpoised to this is ruralism, characterized by stability, integration and rigid stratification, with individuals coming into contact with the same people in a variety of situations. Wirth's dichotomy was one of many proposed throughout the early part of this century in an attempt to distinguish between urban and non-urban societies, in order to map the rapid pace of social change. The principal dichotomies are listed in Table 2. These theoretical ideas influenced some of the early studies of 'rural' communities, such as Rees (1950) and Williams (1956), and have been reviewed by Bell and Newby (1971, 1974) and Symes (1981). However, after pioneering studies by Williams (1963) and Littlejohn (1963), the emphasis on integrated rural stability was increasingly challenged (Symes, 1981).

Researchers soon realized that there was no simple dichotomy between 'rural' and 'urban' areas. Instead, they recognized a variety of communities conforming to various levels of urbanism and ruralism (as defined by Wirth and others). Therefore, the notion of a rural–urban continuum was devised (Redfield, 1941), which positioned settlements along a spectrum ranging from very remote rural areas, through transitional areas, to the modern city. Frankenberg (1966) and Duncan and Reiss (1976) provide a series of studies supposedly situated at various points along this continuum. These studies, in particular, illustrate the continuum's usage as a classificatory device as well as a measure of development.

Table 2. Some urban/rural dichotomies

Author	Urban category	Non-urban category
Becker	Secular	Sacred
Durkheim	Organic solidarity	Mechanical solidarity
Maine	Contract	Status
Redfield	Urban	Folk
Spencer	Industrial	Military
Tonnies	*Gesellschaft*	*Gemeinschaft*
Weber	Rational	Traditional

Source: Reissman (1964), in Phillips and Williams (1984), p. 10.

Pahl (1966, 1970) pioneered the discrediting of the rural–urban continuum principle within British studies. He pointed out that previous work had neglected 'urban' aspects of rural society. Instead, he proposed that we should concentrate on the people living in rural areas rather than on rural areas themselves. Hence, he outlined the characteristics of various 'social groups in the countryside', with the balance between these groups in any specific place being the key. None the less, whilst there are considerable benefits to be gained from concentrating on the 'groups' or, more specifically, the classes which comprise rural populations, such a focus manages to avoid providing any definition of the rural itself, unless it is statistically associated with a certain mix of groups.

Consolidating various criticisms to be made of the rural–urban continuum, Newby (1986) points out how the idea that population density, population size and the general social and physical environment gave rise to a distinct form of society was rapidly demolished by the weight of contradictory evidence. The sociological characteristics of a place could not simply be 'read off' from its relative location on a continuum. For example, Young and Wilmott (1957) found supposedly 'rural' societies in the East End of London (see also Gans, 1962), whilst Pahl (1965) and Connell (1978) found 'urban' societies in Surrey and Hertfordshire, respectively. Nevertheless, the continuum idea survived well into the 1970s (for example, Carlson *et al.*, 1981), aided by the institutional framework in which rural studies was embedded, contributing to what some consider to be a crisis in rural social science (Newby, 1980; Newby and Buttel, 1980; Bradley and Lowe, 1984). Even today, the idea of the urban penetrating the rural community lingers (Hoggart and Buller, 1987); Hoggart (1988, 1990) sees Cloke's index as an expression of continuum ideas.

Whilst neither simple rural–urban dichotomies nor more complex continua work well empirically, these approaches can also be criticized as being theoretically flawed. Studies reflected the penetration of geographical (environmental) determinism into social science, whereby human behaviour and character is determined by the physical environment in which it exists. The specific development of such determinism in rural studies was aided by the combination of structural-functional anthropology and the romanticist defence of supposedly rural culture and traditions (Newby, 1986). Briefly, this isolated the rural as symbolizing a stable, harmonious community, everything 'positive' that

urban life seemed to lack. This was a myth, since the determinists had a misconception of space (and time). Instead, we need an appreciation of rural space which neither prioritizes its empirical structure nor relies upon a false dichotomy between space and society. Defining the rural comes after this.

Conceptualizing space

The principal theoretical criticism of both the descriptive and socio–cultural definitions of the rural is that they demonstrate an erroneous conceptualization of the relationship between space and society. There has recently been a very active debate concerning this relationship (for example, see Gregory and Urry, 1985) and, rather than start from a basic philosophical discussion of space (see Harvey, 1973; Smith, 1984), I shall advocate and seek to justify a position which claims that whilst space has no inherent causal powers (i.e. it is not absolute), whereby a spatial formation can give rise to social practices, neither can it be reduced to the sum of relationships (distances) between objects (i.e. it is not relative). Instead, space and spatial relations are both expressions of underlying structures — space is produced (Smith, 1984) — and a means of creating further spaces — space is a resource (Smith, 1981). This conceptualization of space aims to overcome both spatial determinism, inherent in socio–cultural definitions' association between the rural and a distinctive 'way of life', and spatial indifference, inherent in descriptive definitions' ontological shallowness (Bhaskar, 1975, 1979; Keat and Urry, 1981; Sayer, 1984, 1985; Gregory, 1985).

Spatial (or geographical or environmental) determinism holds an absolute conception of space, whereby space itself possesses causal powers. The rural–urban continuum is an example of such thinking, whereby properties inherent in the rural environment were thought to produce a distinctive rural character. Whilst this 'environment' includes social aspects, therefore going beyond the physical confines of 'environmentalism' (Gold, 1980), the environment is still treated as a 'given' factor, rather than something which is produced (ibid.; Smith, 1984).

In rejecting all that had gone before, many social scientists, particularly in the 1970s, relegated space to the position of being a mere 'reflection' of society, an unimportant detail (Massey, 1985). An example of this 'spatial indifference' comes in a paper by Short (1974) who, following the entreaties of Castells (1977), investigated the city as a spatial product of the economic, political and ideological levels of society (cf. Gregory, 1978a, pp. 118–120). In brief, this alternative argues that environments do not produce societies as these are ultimately defined by the dominant mode of production (Gilbert, 1982). Such a framework could also be used to investigate the rural, but is open to at least three criticisms.

First, although this perspective emphasizes how space is produced (Smith, 1984), it neglects consideration of the extent to which *all* space is produced. The idea that all space is reducible, even ultimately, to the capitalist mode of production appears unduly deterministic and restrictive of human agency (see Sayer, 1989). This criticism applies even if we can still distinguish between socially produced space (spatiality), physical space and mental space (Soja, 1985; cf. Smith, 1984).

Secondly, and similarly, emphasis on 'society' as a whole leads to a neglect of the diversity which exists at a host of levels. Even disaggregating society into a number of levels, which together might be shown to give rise to a distinctive rural society, is inadequate, notwithstanding the need for some generalization. Gould has commented on how generalization destroys so much of what is of interest, asking 'how can we ever believe in the search for laws of human behaviour again?' (1982, p. 78). Reductionism to the lowest common denominator is wide but not very deep.

The third and most serious criticism of spatial indifference is that this conceptualization fails to appreciate the dynamism of space. This comes about through its treatment of society and space as a dualism rather than as a duality (see Giddens, 1984). Whilst it acknowledges that space is produced, it leaves the matter there: space is the *residue* of structures. (This implication also applies when it is accepted that there is no identity between society and space, and even if adequate flexibility of spatial form is allowed.) From this perspective, although looking at space might be useful in providing clues to the underlying structures, study of space itself has little merit.

It has become increasingly clear that indifference to space led to it being unduly marginalized (Massey, 1985). For example, Castells was concerned that:

> It has been a custom in the recent literature . . . to use the formula according to which space is expression of society. Although such a perspective is a healthy reaction against the technological determinism and the short-sighted emphasis too frequently prominent in the space-related disciplines, it is clearly an insufficient formulation of the problem . . . Space is not a 'reflection of society', it *is* society . . . (1983, p. 4, emphasis in original).

Two closely inter-related issues are involved here. First, space is produced, reproduced and transformed by society (Smith, 1984; Harvey, 1985) but this does not make it an 'environment' of social residues, since society only has material existence in a spatio–temporal form; space is society. *Space* represents the meshing together of structures but it also *delineates the structures themselves* (Giddens, 1984). Only in total abstraction are structures aspatial (Sayer, 1985); at the concrete level they take on spatial form, as determined by the spatial arrangement of the contingent forces which activate and sustain them. Giddens (1984) draws attention to the significance of this 'stretching' of social systems, or 'time–space distanciation', for the organization of society and power. In this way, Soja is correct in saying that 'social life is both space-forming and space-contingent' (1985, p. 98), with the social world consisting of 'interdependent, mutually modifying, four-dimensional, space-time entities' (Urry, 1985, p. 28).

Secondly, a dynamic theory recognizes that the space produced is not simply dumped aside as unimportant but is used to (re)produce space, to (re)produce structures and ultimately, to (re)produce society. As Harvey recognized:

> Geographical differentiations . . . frequently appear to be what they are not: mere historical residuals rather than actively reconstituted features within the captialist mode of production (1982, p. 416).

More fundamentally, space is essential for sustaining structures since, to remain current, 'general structures do not float above particular contexts but are always (re)produced within them' (Sayer, 1989, p. 255). Hence, space can be regarded as *a means of production* (see Lefebvre, 1976), most obviously in the transportation industry but also more generally in relation to the quantitative and qualitative form of the land involved in the production process (Smith, 1984, pp. 85–86). The spatial properties of matter are a crucial part of its use value, where:

> The use-value of an object is not inherent in the thing itself but is determined in practice by the object's utility, yet at the same time the use-value has no existence separate from the object. Concerning space, two things follow from this. First, space and spatial properties have no meaning separate from concrete pieces of matter, and second, geographical space is nothing independent of its use (Smith, 1981, p. 115).

In other words, when we consider (rural) space, we must not only consider the structures producing that space but also the way in which that space is subsequently used to produce other space and, fundamentally, to reproduce the original causal structures themselves. Of course, there is still room for the existence of 'unused' relic space, the legacy of past structures, but this space is to be treated as any other object with no use value.

The rural locality

> There is no rural and there is no rural economy. It is merely our analytic distinction, our rhetorical device. Unfortunately we tend to be victims of our own terminological duplicity. We tend to ignore the import of what happens in the total economy and society as it affects the rural sector. We tend to think of the rural sector as a separate entity which can be developed while the non-rural sector is held constant. Our thinking is ensnared by our own words (Copp, 1972, p. 159, quoted in Newby, 1980).

If we are to develop a conception of rural space within social science based on the principles outlined above then we have to satisfy two criteria (Hoggart, 1990, p. 248; see also Cloke, 1980, p. 197, and 1985, p. 6):

(1) There are significant structures operating which are unambiguously associated with the local level.
(2) Looking at these structures enables us to distinguish clearly between an urban and a rural environment.

In short:

> the designation rural would have to identify locations with distinctive causal forces. If these specifications are met, then genuinely local, distinctively rural causal forces can be said to exist (Hoggart, 1990, p. 248).

There is considerable dispute as regards the extent to which the two criteria given above are fulfilled. For example, whilst the current industrial restructuring of space appears to exhibit a rural–urban dimension (for example, see Gould and Keeble, 1984; Fothergill *et al.*, 1985), this appears to be more a reflection of properties contingently found in what we regard as rural areas than an inherent reflection of 'the rural'. Movement of industry out of the cities in recent years reflects, *inter alia*, the search for lower labour costs. If labour costs were to fall in the cities then we might expect much of this outflow to be stemmed and reversed. In other words, the 'ruralization of industry' (Fothergill *et al.*, 1985) appears to be a very precarious phenomenon. The crucial issue is the movement to *low-wage* areas; whether these are 'rural' or 'urban' is largely contingent (see Massey, 1984). Similarly, Moseley (1980a, b) highlighted the overlap between rural and urban deprivation, whilst Friedland (1982) pointed out the need to see the urban-to-rural population turnaround as being urban-based (see

also the examples of 'overlap' given in Hoggart, 1990).

In general, the structuring and restructuring of space and society does not distinguish necessarily between rural and urban areas. The key feature is that it is an *uneven* development, and can take place at a variety of spatial scales. Indeed, when Marx discussed the tendency of space to be annihilated by time, he possibly did not realize the subsequent significance of this process. The separation of town and country, which was a sedimented division of labour, has for many purposes been obliterated (Smith, 1984). The implications from the 'restructuring thesis' (for example, Massey, 1984) is that abstract spatial criteria now have decreased significance compared to factors such as the relative quality and cost of human labour power in different places (Marsden and Murdoch, 1989).

In most circumstances, such as employment, leisure and shopping, the created space of the rural is absorbed within a created space which transcends any rural–urban divide (for example, Coombes *et al.*, 1982; CURDS, 1983–1984; Smith, 1984, p. 136). This is because the spatial 'moments' (dimensions) of the processes with which we are concerned themselves transcend the rural–urban distinction. Indeed, many transcend the distinction between cities and exist within the created absolute space of the nation state, whilst others are still more transcendent. Like a distorted Russian doll, there are a myriad of structural levels in society, attached to which are distinct geographical spaces (Urry, 1985) or 'fields of effectivity' (Gregory, 1985). For Thrift, the urban-to-rural shift in population merely reflects the infilling of urban space, since 'the South of England is now one vast created and manicured urban–suburban space' (1987, p. 77).

Giddens (1984 and elsewhere) says much the same, although he expresses it somewhat more relativistically when he claims that there are dominant 'locales', defined as settings for interaction (created absolute spaces), which are made heterogenous through 'regionalization', either temporally, spatially or temporal–spatially. Whilst in a 'class-divided society' the dominant locale organization centred around the 'symbiosis of city and countryside', by the time we get to a 'class society' (capitalism) the dominant locale organization is the 'created environment', for which most authors use the somewhat confusing euphemism 'urban'.

Rural *localities* (see Urry, 1986a; cf. Newby, 1986; Jonas, 1988; Duncan and Savage, 1989), if they are to be recognized and studied as categories in their own right, must therefore be carefully defined according to that which makes them *rural*. None of the previously discussed definitions has adequately achieved this, although the rigorousness introduced by the society–space debate should enable us to further this goal more adequately in the future.

What features are likely to assume prime importance in the creation of such a definition (see also Pahl, 1970; Moseley, 1980b; Cloke and Park, 1984)? First, there is the link between the rural and the *agricultural* (Newby, 1978). From an economic viewpoint, this is to associate rural space with primary production (Gilbert, 1982) or with 'the competitive sector' (Hoggart and Buller, 1987). However, many urban localities could be similarly classified (ibid.). The social distinctiveness of agriculture necessary for such a definition has also been questioned (Bradley, 1981; Barlow, 1986; Hoggart and Buller, 1987).

Secondly, there is the connection between the rural and issues of 'collective consumption', the key being the effect of *low population densities* (Urry, 1984). This is clearly very socially and historically specific and its overall importance is debatable, especially given the decline in the importance of the friction of distance (Hoggart and Buller, 1987; Marsden and Murdoch, 1989).

Thirdly, following Bradley (1981), Thrift (1987) and Marsden and Murdoch (1989), we may wish to stress rural space's more general role in *consumption*, whether collective (for example, national parks) or privatized (for example, residence). As such, this requires us to more fully examine competing social representations of rurality (see Mormont, 1987), as introduced in the next section (see also Halfacree, 1992, pp. 110–203).

Not being convinced by any of these arguments, Hoggart (1988, 1990; Hoggart and Buller, 1987) wants to 'do away with rural', as he sees it as a confusing 'chaotic conception' lacking explanatory power. Instead, we are better off looking at extra-rural structures and processes, notwithstanding that these are moulded by local circumstances. The key issue for him is that these local processes are not generalizable into the terms 'rural' or 'urban'. 'Rural' places are not identical, with any similarities that they do possess not being significantly different from many features of 'urban' places:

> the undifferentiated use of 'rural' in a research context is detrimental to the advancement of social theory . . . The broad category 'rural' is obfuscatory, whether the aim is description or theoretical evaluation, since intra-rural differences can be enormous and rural–urban similarities can be sharp (Hoggart, 1990, p. 245).

In short, 'causal processes do not stop at one side of the urban–rural divide' (Hoggart, 1988, p. 36; see also Zelinsky, 1977). Nevertheless, if Hoggart's thesis becomes widely accepted then this does *not* have the necessary corollary that we have to assign 'the rural' to the dustbin of research history. This is because there is yet another means of defining the rural, which directs our attention to the realm of discourse and the theory of social representations.

The rural as social representation: 'invisible only to the clever'?

There is an alternative way of defining rurality which, initially, does not require us to abstract causal structures operating at the rural scale. This alternative comes about because 'the rural' and its synonyms are *words and concepts understood and used by people in everyday talk*. Copp's claim that 'Our thinking is ensnared by our own words' (1972, p. 159) is thus extremely astute and requires us to investigate the status of the rural in discourse since 'rural is just a symbolic shorthand (as are all concepts) by which we mean to encapsulate something' (Falk and Pinhey, 1978, p. 553). First, however, it is necessary to introduce the theory of 'social representations', which I believe provides a necessary theoretical background for such an investigation but has been largely neglected in the current theoretical debates within the 'rural' literature (but see Harper, 1987b; Falk and Pinhey, 1978).

The theory of social representations

The theory of social representations, as developed principally in the work of Moscovici (1976, 1981, 1982, 1984; see also Potter and Wetherell, 1987), attempts to outline how people understand, explain and articulate the complexity of stimuli and experiences emanating from the social and physical environment in which they are immersed (cf. Schutz, 1967). In contrast to orthodox social psychology, social representation theory rejects the idea that everyday behaviour involves a 'scientific' approach to objects, people and events, where understanding is merely information processing (Moscovici, 1984). This 'academic fallacy' (Thrift, 1986; see also Shotter, 1984) assumes that people act logically, systematically and rationally, as if guided by an 'inner, on-board computer' (Thrift, 1986, p. 87), abstracting from the everyday realities of the social world. Instead, social representation theory argues that renewed importance needs to be attached to the 'paramount realities of everyday life' (Schutz, 1970), an important component of which is what Giddens (1984) has termed 'practical consciousness'. This is in line with Falk's and Pinhey's (1978) call for rural studies to pay greater attention to Schutz's constitutive phenomenology, with its concern with the socially and situationally specific 'actor's view of the world' (see also Harper, 1987b).

Following the 'symbolic interaction' tradition of Mead (1934), Moscovici (1984) proposes that people use social representations in order to deal with the complexity of the social world. These are defined as organizational mental constructs which guide us towards what is 'visible' and must be responded to, relate appearance and reality, and even define reality itself. The world is organized, understood and mediated through these basic cognitive units. Social representations consist of both concrete images and abstract concepts, organized around 'figurative nuclei' which are 'a complex of images that visibly reproduce . . . a complex of ideas' (ibid., p. 38). Therefore, whilst they are partly a description of the physical material world, social representations are irreducible to it. They are both iconic and symbolic.[1]

We use social representations in two main ways. First, they enable us to conventionalize the objects, persons and events encountered. Secondly, they help us to prescribe and organize our subsequent behaviour and responses (see also Brewer, 1988, p. 155, on 'descriptive vocabularies'). In Shields' (1991) terms,[2] they are both referential and anticipatory. Prescription/anticipation makes social representations not merely neutral and reactive but also creative and transformative, through their usage by people trying to go about their everyday lives:

> Rather than motivations, aspirations, cognitive principles and the other factors that are usually put forward, it is our representations which, in the last resort, determine our reactions, and their significance is, thus, that of an actual cause (Moscovici, 1984, p. 65).

This usage, which takes place in changing world contexts, makes social representations dynamic and ever-adapting to new circumstances.

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[1] Pocock and Hudson (1978) make a similar point by distinguishing between the designative and appraisive aspects of images.

[2] Shields' book on 'places on the margin' develops what he terms a theory of social spatialisation, which is very close to the version of the theory of social representations developed here, except that it is restricted to spatial phenomena and contains immediate material as well as mental components:

> I use the term *social spatialisation* to designate the ongoing social construction of the spatial at the level of the social imaginary (collective mythologies, presuppositions) as well as interventions in the landscape (for example, the built environment) (Shields, 1991, p. 31).

Moscovici's social representations, although concentrating on signification and meaning, display similarities with the 'virtual' structures proposed by Giddens (1984) — in their lack of a subject, in the necessity for their constant reproduction, and in their status as 'rules' (interpretative schemes and norms) and 'resources'. Representations are not tied to specific 'individuals', be they people, objects or places. This is in contrast to studies in the spatial cognition literature, such as Lee (1968) and Lynch (1960), where spatial images tend to be related to specific city areas and, as a result, lose some of their powerful flexibility (Canter, 1977).

It is important to stress the *social* aspect of representations (Gregory, 1978b). They are consensual means of making the unfamilair familiar, but this consensus is group-specific. Only those who share a representation will use it the same way, having a similar understanding and evaluation of the aspects of the world being covered (Potter and Wetherell, 1987). Moreover, social representations are also inherently social through their linkage to communication processes and because they require an agreed code for this communication (ibid.). Hence, issues of knowledgeability and the political economy of the structural acquisition of this knowledge (Thrift, 1985) are crucial to social representations.

Potter and Wetherell (1987; see also Potter and Litton, 1985) outline the difficulties of linking specific social representations with specific groups and of defining a satisfactory degree of consensus within such a group. They also question the overly cognitive status of the representations, as this underplays their context-dependency. In sum, they argue that the role of *language* has been underplayed and they introduce a rival concept, namely the 'interpretative repertoire'. This is 'a lexicon or register of terms and metaphors drawn upon to characterize and evaluate actions and events' (Potter and Wetherell, 1987, p. 138). The repertoire exists within discourse alone, rather than referring back to an image (see Gilbert and Mulkay, 1984).

Unlike social representations, interpretive repertoires are not intrinsically linked to social groups, these being constructed in the course of the accounts themselves. In addition, there is no search for consensus, as people frequently switch between repertoires in any account and use different aspects of the repertoire in different circumstances. Finally, there is no cognitive reductionism in repertoires, concern being almost solely with language use and function.

It would appear that both parties in this debate tend to overstate their respective cases. This makes them appear unduly incompatible. Criticisms of Moscovici are well-founded if the theory of social representations attempts to extend itself directly into the realm of discourse. However, in a similar manner, problems emerge when interpretative repertoires are extended back from the realm of discourse into the structural realm. The latter is attempted negatively through considering nothing apart from 'talk'. As Bowers (1988) points out, the whole tone of Potter's and Wetherell's (1987) book is relativist and over-idealist, resulting in an unwarranted rejection of realist ontology and truth claims. Excessive power is attributed to language as a creative force, neglecting its role as a communicator of information *about* the world, whether 'correctly' perceived or not. The groups which language creates usually have some material referent, whether people or things.

A development of this idealism is that Potter and Wetherell prioritize the 'hubbub' of language at the expense of the more 'structured' but 'quieter' mental realm of representation. The latter is less transient and context-specific than language, and provides the foundation for talk; interpretive repertoires thus have a referent. This is not to claim that discourse is determined by mental constructs but to assert that language is not as free-floating and self-referential as Potter seems to claim. There is more to the process of discourse than the shallowness of language. Moreover, as Moscovici points out, 'all that is image or concept does not entirely pass into language' (1985, p. 92) but nevertheless can influence the course of social interaction. Articulation of ideas within language should not be equated with articulation of ideas (Hewstone, 1985).

Both Moscovici and Potter neglect the socio-political processes involved in the production, reproduction and mediation of social representations (Semin, 1985; Bowers, 1988). They appear over-voluntaristic, although probably this mostly reflects the academic division of labour. As Moscovici makes clear, social representations are independent stimuli for social psychologists but require explanation within other disciplines (1984, p. 61). Nevertheless, this constraint does not justify the lack of attention given to the process of choice between competing social representations or interpretative repertoires in specific circumstances (Bowers, 1988). This issue, including the link between social representations and groups, requires that more attention is given to the 'political economy of social representations' than has been the case to date.

I would like to suggest that Moscovici's original theory of social representations needs to restrict itself to the realm of mental constructs — the disembodied structures — informing discourse and

action. Similarly, Potter's interpretative repertoires should be confined to the realm of discourse, where social representations are drawn upon in a specific, context-dependent and partial manner, in order to pursue discursive actions. They may also be drawn upon non-discursively, as they inform physical actions as well. In short, there is an ontological difference between social representations and interpretative repertoires. The latter are the modalities of social representations within a specific instance of discourse; they link structures and interaction (see Giddens, 1984, p. 29). Both merit study, especially the content of the representations and the specificities of their usage.

Classifying discourses

Our attempts at defining the rural can be termed 'academic discourses' (Sayer, 1989) because they are the constructs of academics attempting to understand, explain and manipulate the social world (cf. Schutz, 1970). They are mostly carefully formulated 'theories', possessing a rigour not apparent in everyday 'accounts' (Thrift, 1986) or 'lay narratives' (Sayer, 1989). The relationships between these contrasting ways of dealing with objects in the world are illustrated in Fig. 1.

Academic discourses are pivoted between talking about their objects (for example, the rural) and talking about lay discourses on these objects (see also Falk and Pinhey, 1978). Neglect of how lay discourses underpin academic discourses leads to a certain self-referentiality and, hence, to a circularity when attempts at definition are involved. For example, as illustrated earlier, in trying to establish an academic definition of the rural, many of the descriptive definitions referred back to our 'commonsense', intuitive idea of the rural: they tried to express the rural rather than define it.

Failure to recognize the non-objectivity underpinning academic discourses has a number of other negative implications. Most seriously, it overlooks the way in which different interests are promoted through the objectification of these discourses (Rodwin and Hollister, 1984). For example, Appleyard (1979) comments on how a 'professional and scientific' view of the environment suppresses meaning and how its deliberate de-symbolization legitimates dealing with it technically and apolitically. These issues have been most fully developed by Habermas (for example, Habermas, 1972) in his investigation of the cognitive interests implied by different types of science and forms of knowledge. Eliot Hurst (1980, 1985) has taken up this issue in his deconstruction of 'the church of geography'.

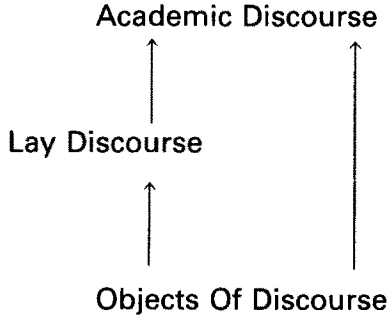


Figure 1. The relationship between discourses and objects. (*Source*: based on Sayer, 1989, p. 262).

Hoggart's (Hoggart, 1988, 1990; Hoggart and Buller, 1987) criticism of attempts at defining the rural can thus be seen as a call for a more direct engagement between academic discourse and its object (the rural). However, to proceed in this manner alone would be to neglect the lay discourses of rurality, which would be effectively marginalized as partial/inaccurate versions of the rural-as-locality object. Moreover, as Hoggart questions whether the latter has any significant existence, the lay discourses can be regarded as myths which need to be discarded.

Elsewhere in the academic literature, attention is also being paid to the left-hand side of Fig. 1. There is a growing realization of the necessity of studying people's accounts of the form, content and context of their daily lives as the relationship between structure and agency is reassessed after the excesses of structuralism (for example, see Thrift, 1983; Giddens, 1984, 1986; Shotter, 1984). As Giddens puts it: 'the technical concepts of social science are, and must be, parasitical upon lay concepts' (1987, p. 70). Rural social scientists have at least been as guilty as anyone else in neglecting the ordinary person's view of the world, leading to a 'theoretical–empirical myopia' (Falk and Pinhey, 1978). The social world must be regarded as an ongoing accomplishment, not a taken-for-granted facticity (ibid.). A retreat from theory is not involved here:

> Lay-knowledge or practical consciousness are only atheoretical in the sense that their conceptualisations and claims are relatively unexamined. Since lay-knowledge is both part of our object, and a rival account of it, our response to it must not be to dismiss it, but rather to examine it. There are no philosophically defensible grounds for using the term 'theory' as many (often otherwise sophisticated) social scientists do — where the only distinguishable feature of 'theoretical' terms is their unfamiliar or esoteric character in relation to lay vocabularies . . . [The] double hermeneutic of social science requires us to understand and negotiate with 'actors' accounts', not to dismiss them in order to maintain the purity of what we like to call theory (Sayer, 1989, p. 267).

Similar sentiments have been expressed by Geertz:

> Some of the most crucial properties of the world are . . . invisible only to the clever . . . [The] world is a various place . . . and much is to be gained . . . by confronting that grand actuality rather than wishing it away in a haze of faceless generalities and false comforts (1983, pp. 89, 234).

The theory of social representations allows us to reconcile Hoggart's doubts regarding the existence of the rural locality with this call for greater attention to be paid to lay discourses. This is because *'the rural' should not be seen as a singular object of discourse*: Hoggart's object of discourse is the rural as locality, whereas the object of discourse implicated in the lay discourses is the social representation of rurality. Whilst these two objects of discourse should not be regarded as mutually exclusive — hence the descriptive and socio-cultural definitions' rootedness both in a commonsense understanding of the rural and in the rural as locality — they are none the less different. Lay discourses are thus not to be regarded as being rooted in a probable myth but should be seen as interpretive repertoires derived from a disembodied but none the less real social representation of the rural.

If we are to accept the status of the rural as a social representation, we can see further evidence for the importance of not sticking to the right-hand side of Fig. 1. Given the disembodied and virtual character of the social representation, to attempt to interrogate them directly would be to neglect the interpretive repertoires that grounded the representation by giving it a subject through discourse, and in the process serve to articulate, reproduce and sometimes transform the underlying representation itself. Hence, the significance of their contextual usage would be missed (Shotter, 1985). Sayer came to a similar conclusion, albeit as regards a somewhat different subject matter:

> to be good causal analysts we need to explain things in relation to their 'causal contexts', abstracting from unrelated phenomena operating in different causal contexts. A purely causal analysis of the industrial base of Los Angeles would instantly make us forget its ironies by resolving them into separate causal groups. But what we would overlook is precisely the fact that the society in question does split into these contexts of determination rather than other ones; we would miss the significance of the fact that the division of areas of action is made *this* way, in practice (1989, p. 273, emphasis in original).

[3]Shields (1991) would term the rural social representation a 'place-myth' but this perpetuates the idea that such structures are in some way 'unreal' because they lack *direct* material grounding.

Whilst our social representations of 'the rural' may be fetishized and misplaced, distorted, idealized and generalized, they nevertheless produce very 'real' effects. Social representations provide resources for both discursive and non-discursive actions. The rural social representation[3] — a 'symbolic shorthand' (Falk and Pinhey, 1978) — both guides and constrains action (Shields, 1991, p. 30). It must be seen as causative, 'channelling' causation, although not causal (ibid., p. 57; see also Sayer, 1985).

Social representations of the rural: problems and prospects

Constructing a representational definition of the rural requires a strongly hermeneutical and interpretive methodology (Falk and Pinhey, 1978; Harper, 1987b; Shields, 1991; see also Pile, 1991) because of the need to deal directly with lay discourses. This task, difficult in itself, is compounded by a number of factors. First, the context-dependence of the interpretive repertoires employed (see also Gilbert and Mulkay, 1984; Potter and Wetherell, 1987) means that the social representation from which they derive may contain diverse and even contradictory elements. The latter is possible not only because of such components not being expressed together through individual interpretive repertoires but also because of the location of much of the 'knowledge' contained in the interpretive repertoires at the level of 'practical consciousness' (Thrift, 1985; see also Giddens, 1984, 1986; Shotter, 1984, 1985).

Social representations of space provide 'a means to express ideas' (Shields, 1991, p. 46) through interpretive repertoires but the latter provide:

> *an intellectual shorthand* whereby spatial metaphors and place images can convey a complex set of associations *without the speaker having to think deeply and to specify exactly* which associations or images he or she intends (ibid., my emphases).

Indeed, the construction and usage of social representations of space 'is not a primarily conceptual or logical process' but is 'internalised through the 'embodied' memory of habit, gesture, and spatial practice' (ibid., p. 264). As such, we can see immediately the challenge faced by researchers in bringing to the surface and exposing the usage of social representations of the rural through discourse.

Another difficulty facing researchers stems from abstractness and disembodied character of social

representations, which means they may not be at all clearly delineated. Such a lack of empirical clarity will make it harder to reconstruct these representations, especially given their probable contradictory character, as outlined above. However, some help can be gained by seeing what Shields rather grandly terms a 'modern geomancy' in the interrelation between representations, where:

> places or regions mean something only in relation to other places as a constellation of meanings, that is, the North makes sense only with reference to other regions: the 'urban jungle', the southern agricultural fringe, or the commodified consumer landscape of Toronto's suburban strip developments. The images are oriented towards each other in a mutually supporting dialogical exchange (Bakhtin, 1984, pp. 10–12) (1991, p. 199).

The key task may not be to define the rural social representation in the abstract — indeed, this is not the implication of the contextual model of society — but the apparently more relativist task of comparing and contrasting them, through their interpretive repertoires, with other spatial social representations. Hence, we must not be too eager to discard the idea of the social representation of the rural just because our research discovers that people do not hold a clear, well-defined and well-structured 'image' of 'the rural'.

A final compounding factor in our attempt to expose social representations of the rural requires us to consider the distinction between the sign and both its significant (meaning) and its referent (Barthes, 1967). In his attempt to promote a representational definition of the rural, Pratt (1989) saw the sign ('rurality') as being increasingly detached from its signification — in my terminology, social representations and interpretive repertoires of the rural are becoming increasingly diverse. In addition, the sign and its significant are also becoming divorced from their referent (the rural locality), leading to cross-cutting discourse about rurality (ibid.). This promotes the everyday significance of the rural as a social representation *vis-à-vis* the rural as locality (see also Shields, 1991, p. 50). More controversially, it can also be seen as symptomatic of a turn towards socio-cultural post-modernism, where the symbolic assumes precedence over the material (see Baudrillard, 1983, 1988). Finally, the severing of the social representation of the rural from any material referent also makes the former a site of social struggle within discourse, as promoters of competing representations strive for hegemony.

This struggle has been illustrated by Mormont (1987) in his discussion of the emergence of the regional nature park idea in Belgium. Three representations of the rural — the conservationist's stress on 'heritage', the 'neo-ruralist's stress on 'tradition' and the devolutionist's stress on 'external threats' — came together in the proposal for nature parks. These three representations can all be described as both élite (noble) and intellectual (heavy) (see Bourdieu, 1984, pp. 260–317). The clearest evidence for this comes from their prioritization of knowledge over money, in contrast to the predominant currents of contemporary society. Moreover, they also clashed with alternative representations of the rural and the countryside, particularly those of modernizing agriculturalists and proponents of mass tourism, who both emphasized the physical use-value of rural space. For these latter two groups, the rural was to be materially exploited and developed, not symbolically contemplated and regarded as a source of spirituality.

The dynamism of these representations — indeed the very emergence of 'the rural' as a representation — further undermines the validity of using a purely 'material' definition of the rural. This is because Mormont, too, recognized that the social representation of the rural was becoming increasingly divorced from the rural space which it nominally represented. Hence, he asks:

> Where earlier we talked of the rural world in order to define a separate and distinct universe . . . are we not now moving towards another representation which considers things rural not as belonging to another social world, but as a different mode of social relationship? (1987, p. 17).

The physical use of rural space, which has resulted in its 'reduction . . . to a mosaic of countrysides' (ibid., p. 18) primarily dictated to from within the overall urban space, is to be distinguished from the representation of rural space. For Mormont, the latter has an ideological component as it informs a social project which is not confined to the rural space of physical use. Rurality is materially despatialized, as the 'sense of' the rural is separated from its 'existential realness' (Falk and Pinhey, 1978).

Finally, the precise structure of our social representation of rurality is not easy to indicate. It will be an amalgam of personal experiences and 'traditional' handed-down beliefs propagated through literature, the media, the state, family, friends and institutions (Gould, 1977; Pocock and Hudson, 1978; for example, see Blishen, 1984). This 'knowledge' will be both spatially and socially variable (Thrift, 1985). As most of our daily life is carried on at the empirical level (Tuan, 1989), the world of surface appearances may be expected to predominate within representations of rurality. The definitional wheel may thus appear to have turned full circle, taking us back to

regarding the rural as a descriptive category,[4] although this time with a sounder conceptualization of space and an explicit engagement with the 'commonsense' underlying these descriptions. Moreover, the 'new' descriptive category can no longer be regarded as a singular objective category but one which is specific to class, gender, ethnicity, etc.

Conclusion

For Falk and Pinhey (1978), the tendency to discuss the rural in a taken-for-granted manner reifies the concept and neglects any questioning of its 'reality'. Whilst one may wish to be wary of distinguishing between the 'real' and the 'unreal' rural, there is a growing realization in the literature that the quest for any single, all-embracing definition of the rural is neither desirable nor feasible. Increasingly, there is a call for the definition to be used to be tailored to the task at hand (for example, Matthews, 1988; Hoggart, 1990). One response to this would be to propose a compound definition of the rural which would attempt to capture the multiple meanings of the word (for example, Willits and Bealer, 1967; Cloke and Park, 1984) but this would be to downplay the situated specificity of these multiple meanings which is precisely that which must be of interest to researchers (Falk and Pinhey, 1978).

This paper has proposed an alternative response, which should enable us to impose some order on the diversity of the rural without losing the significance of this diversity. I have argued that the problem in the literature stems from a failure to distinguish between the rural as a distinctive type of locality and the rural as a social representation — the rural as space and the rural as representing space — confounded by other difficulties, such as the inadequate conceptualization of space.

In an era described by some as post-modern, where symbols appear increasingly to be 'freed' from their referential moorings, it is increasingly important to acknowledge explicitly this difference between space and its social representation. Indeed, we may have to recognize that whilst the referent — the rural locality — may be withering away in respect to its causal significance and distinctiveness (assuming such a salience ever really existed), its nominally associated social representation may well be flourishing and evolving. With the utilization of social representations of space, 'material space' is 're-coded' (Shields, 1991, p. 264). Space becomes imbued with the characteristics of these representations, not only at an imaginative level but also physically, through the use of these representations in action.

As regards the rural, if the 'material space' of the rural is no longer the rural locality but the 'material space' created through usage of the rural social representation, then the much-derided 'chocolate box' countryside may not be(come) such a myth, after all:

> Abstraction today is no longer that of the map, the double, the mirror or the concept. Simulation is no longer that of a territory, a referential being or a substance. It is the generation by models of a real without origin or reality: a hyperreal. The territory no longer precedes the map, nor survives it. Henceforth, it is the map that precedes the territory — *precession of simulacra* — it is the map that engenders the territory . . . (Baudrillard, 1988, p. 166).

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[4] Rurality as a 'way of life' can also be salvaged in a similar manner. The basis for such a way of life rests on people's usage of social representations to create a specific kind of world; it has nothing to do with any inherent causal powers of the rural environment (see Falk and Pinhey, 1978). As with the 'new' descriptive category, this 'way of life' must be seen as being specific to class, gender, ethnicity, etc.

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